

GEMC 3001 Service Learning / Civic Engagement

Service-Learning Journal (Greece)

WONG, Hok Fong Silas (1155189917)

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Section I.

Pre-Trip Work	Date: April 17 - May 14, 2024	Hong Kong & Macau
Meeting: <i>GEMC3001 Pre-trip Group Meeting</i> I had to attend the pre-trip meeting before the examination week, mainly about the incoming service-learning trip plans and preparations. Before that, I listened to the podcast audio, even though I still did not have a clear picture of what the course components would be. The key takeaways from the podcast are that we will only be able to accept information from the service providers by showing our curiosity with insightful questions. Also, the trip is categorized as “service-learning,” where we engage with non-governmental organizations (NGOs), performing critical evaluations related to operational structures and how challenges related to refugees and asylum seekers are tackled, rather than performing an assistive role in service, which we are warned can be detrimental (side note: as a foreword to Ivan Illich’s “To Hell with Good Intentions,” that we directly went on a field trip without contexts). While I wished to receive a framework of what to incorporate for a critical evaluation of an organization that is solid and objective, the meeting instead asked our students to tackle the big problem ourselves, which puzzled me as there is no prerequisite (and in other words, no specific training, only with imaginations and oral/textual descriptions). All these concerns and rough thoughts comprise a vague, fuzzy picture in my mind, which seems to have no solution at first. I jotted down the three questions on the PowerPoint slides and left the thoughts underneath the tight schedule, as the meeting proceeded. ● <i>Why not just donate the total cost of the service trip directly to organizations?</i> (i) Philanthropy works at cross-purposes, investing more in problems than funding solutions, as it may sometimes prioritize short-term fixes or interventions that provide immediate relief but do not address the structural issues that perpetuate the problems. (ii) Foreign aid can be misused, in an ineffective way (from the podcast). (iii) If we <i>assume</i> that our service trip indeed carries values that are sustained throughout our whole lives, by viewing the trip as an eye-opener that we actively engage ourselves as global citizens and understand the globe’s most pressing problems, then by the principle of maximum utility, we will opt for the trip. (iv) By understanding the nuances of NGO work and the challenges they face, we may be able to advocate for change, support effective initiatives, and promote social justice issues. ● <i>If you notice NGOs doing work that is different from what you would expect, how can you tell if the work is effective or not?</i> (i) It is important to review the NGOs’ mission statements and assess whether their activities are aligned with their stated goals. This may reflect on the transparency of their work since an organization’s motto constitutes the very first impression to the public. (ii) Cross-verification. I believe that benchmarking the NGO’s work with proximal organizations in the field is a qualitative measure. Through comparison and critical reflections, an NGO could gain insights into its performance, strengths and areas of improvements that are valuable for improvements. (iii) Partnership and collaborations: Strong partnerships with peer organizations indicate a sustainable approach to development work, reducing overlaps and maximizing the outcome when working in the field where jobs would be distributed by their own capability and strengths.		

(iv) Perspective-taking: Nothing less than a complete commitment toward the community should exist. In Greece, within a complex environment, organizations must fully respect their relationships with the refugees and asylum seekers they serve and eliminate the concerns raised by the residents. How would they demonstrate humanity toward different groups?

- *Is it more important to serve locally or internationally?*

For one second, I wonder if I can restructure the question by replacing “serve locally or internationally” with the choice between “make in-depth connection” and “recognize wider problems.” However, the answer is often assumed to be NO. (*Why?* Perhaps the scope of discussion is then limited.) It seems that the answer is rather open-ended, depending on the situation of an organization about its capability, or perhaps the struggle of implementing donors’ wills, and the nature of the problem that it selects to consider.

As we all left the classroom, some small talks were initiated, mostly about the motivation of participating in the trip. Silently listening, without excess judgments, to my peers’ reactions, it became apparent that most people opt for the trip instead of providing service, for an excursion and as a step out of the ordinary student life. For me, it is more of a realistic concern, to catch up with the graduation requirements. Anyways, most of us had our minds filled with sketches of Greece and picturesque imaginations, which were not completely related to the service component at all. At the very least, I was happy traveling with some friends and some acquaintances.

Pre-trip Assignment

Having attended 6 examinations without proper rest has left me exhausted for the pre-trip assignments. The lack of time and deficit in the field of social problems and issues have constrained the depth of research effort taken for the assignments. I was physically challenged by my feebleness (lack of SLEEP) and mentally disconnected from the world without a sense of time passing by.

I spent a lot of time trying to understand what Ivan Illich meant. The most interesting observation is how he showed the concept of *alienation* through overseas short-term service, similar to Marx’s. Looking back, I think I was a bit optimistic about how the love existing in the world could make the world better. Isn’t it another form of good intention that causes destruction? I also believe that students from our college could bring fresh perspectives for better discussions.

The two journal articles distributed by the college tutors are dedicated to providing me insights about the situations of medical aid in Greece. Inside of me, there was grief about what happened to Greece due to its long-term suffering from its economic crises. Other than that, I found it hard to absorb anything by just reading the textual materials. I am mostly baffled by the fact that these articles only touched upon the very surface of the issue by simply surveying and reporting the data, assuming the refugee problem as a well-known (which should be challenged) issue that does not require further explanation. Even worse, I found that there were super basic arithmetic errors (many typos) about the statistics in one of the papers, which impacted the inner value of the paper. Eventually, what I learned are the basic information and the terms used for describing medical access and the situations in Greece, in a sociological context.

As we were required to connect the issue to Hong Kong, I found it nearly impossible to search for anything about medical aid for refugees except for a heart-breaking article that describes the situation of asylum seekers detained in Castle Peak Bay Immigration Centre (CIC). The comprehensive [review](#) stood out of all the scholarly journal articles and caught my eye with its power of words. “*One death is a tragedy. One million is a statistic.*” The ignorance of the Legislative Council in addressing critical issues has resulted in the denial of refugee rights, including access to asylum procedures, legal protection, and basic services, leaving them in a state of limbo and insecurity.

Section II.

Day 1	Date: June 8, 2024	Athens, Greece
Observations: <i>Visit to HERC – Greece 101 & Survival Guide</i> After the long flight and checking into the hotel, we immediately headed to the Hellenic Education and Research Center. We were welcomed with food and drinks that made me feel home. During the time we stayed in HERC's classroom, Dr. Jason R. Harris had introduced us the long history of migration waves in Greece, enriching the contextual understanding of the social mobility problem that we aimed to explore. His specialization of Classical and Mediterranean Studies was signified by how he was able to remember all details without looking at a script or notes. I jotted down some important terms that reconstructed this period of history as I had to focus on Dr. Harris's lecture. - "<i>Metics</i>": In ancient times, Greeks had already established colonies throughout the Mediterranean and Black Sea regions. The unique class of foreign residents who held a distinct social and legal status within the city-state is called "metics," which is considerably different from slaves, equipped with legal protections. - "<i>Empires</i>": During the Byzantine Empire period, multiple trade routes, strategic ports, military campaigns and invasions by various groups such as Goths, Vandals and Slavs led to population movements. The Byzantine Empire's collapse further led to population movements and the arrival of various groups in Greece. Then, the Ottoman Empire ruled Greece for centuries. - "<i>Treaties</i>": The Greco-Turkish War (1919-1922) and the Treaty of Lausanne, which involved a population exchange between Greece and Turkey, led to the forced migration of millions of Greeks and Turks. During World War II and the Greek Civil War (1946-1949), many Greeks were displaced internally and externally, seeking refuge in other countries. In the post-war period, Greece experienced significant emigration, with many Greeks leaving for countries like the United States, Canada, Australia, and Germany in search of better economic opportunities. - "<i>The Maastricht Treaty and Schengen Agreement</i>": The Maastricht Treaty, signed in 1992, played a significant role in shaping European integration. Under this treaty, Greece has to adapt to increased mobility of EU citizens, which poses a pressure. The Schengen Agreement signed in 1985 have also further strained the border control policy related to migration and asylum. After this historical journey, we had a short but fruitful discussion session with Dr. Harris. Unfortunately, with my poor background in World History, I had chosen to focus entirely on appreciating what elements have been incorporated to form a good question. Clearly, previous knowledge is one of these. The best part about the discussion was that my peers showed genuine curiosity, which eventually encouraged information exchange throughout the interaction.		
Reflections: My expectation was to learn how to measure the effectiveness of NGOs by the end of the trip. I also plan to complete most of the additional readings during the trip to enrich my understanding of the difficulties faced by the targeted group. Entering uncharted territory, I prepared myself for any opportunity that might appear and <i>expected the unexpected</i>. During the flight to Greece, I listened to the radio podcast on the topic of Multipliers and Diminishers by Liz Wiseman. It explained how the thoughts of multipliers could foster the use of opportunity, motivating people to stretch themselves beyond existing know-how, discover and execute optimal solutions. As questioners, I believe that this podcast relates our trip to how we assumed ourselves to be insightful and devoted. Our different fields of focus in university education could complement each other, removing obstacles that lead to the "<i>success</i>" of our trip (by asking good questions). Given that our group could not directly ask refugees about their major health demands and barriers, I anticipated that we had to consider adapting ourselves to a more flexible position and research more about the organizations before the visit. In GEMC1001, I tried my best to analyze dilemmas from multiple perspectives (views and stakeholders). The Greece trip was no exception. While arguments are signed to protect refugees by providing shelters for living, the parasitic relationship between citizens and asylum seekers can be intense, making the real situation different from what is described in the agreements. Providing benefits to refugees, such as housing, healthcare, education, and social support, often requires government expenditure. However, the source of these expenditures must come from local taxpayers. History often		

provides clues to the dynamic changes in demographic structures and cultural enlightenment, adding depth to dilemmas.

Understanding the challenges that “pull” people to migrate has helped me appreciate the resilience and strength of those seeking better opportunities elsewhere. On the flip side, learning about the “push” factors that attract migrants to new countries due to economic opportunities, political stability, and better living conditions makes me reflect on the privileges and advantages that some of us may take for granted. It highlights the importance of creating inclusive societies that welcome diversity and offer opportunities for growth and prosperity to those in need. Compassionating with the struggles faced by individuals who are forced to leave their homes due to political instabilities, poverty, or environmental factors has left me with a desire to contribute positively to creating a more equitable and supportive world for all individuals, regardless of their backgrounds or circumstances.

Question: *Why Greece still showed vulnerability of migration waves despite the long history?*

- Unlike the history where “metics” were recognized by the neighborhoods and local authorities, asylum seekers in modern times must formally be identified to ensure the protection of rights, track of movements and provision of support. In modern times, asylum seekers are handled through a series of procedures that includes registration, interview screening and documentation to ensure their challenged safety or well-being.
- While refugees are living in limbo, “metics” played a significant role in the economy of ancient Greek city-states. They were involved in trade, crafts, and other economic activities that contributed to the prosperity of the city.
- The massive influx is unforeseen. The infrastructure and resources in Greece are limited. High unemployment rates and austerity measures play an important role in contemporary times.

Day 2	Date: June 9, 2024	Athens, Greece
Observations: <i>Modern Greek Lesson</i> We spent around 90 minutes learning Greek, which was a fun experience. I was surprised that some of my classmates had actively participated in the pronunciation exercises. Learning a new language, especially with the fact that Greek (Hellenic branch of the Indo-European language family) and English (Germanic language within the Indo-European family) are from different linguistic roots, has proven to be difficult. While there are some words with common origins due to historical interactions between the two languages (<i>salad</i> and <i>σαλάτα</i> [<i>salata</i>], for example), the majority of vocabulary in Greek and English is distinct. Also, Greek uses a subject-object-verb order, which is different from what English typically follows, the subject-verb-object order. Nouns even have different forms for case, gender (for example, masculine: <i>σουβλάκι</i> [<i>souvlaki</i>], feminine: <i>πίτα</i> [<i>pita</i>]), and number. Moreover, there are only 24 alphabetical letters in Greek, leading to different sounds and phonemes compared to English and distinct pronunciation patterns. <i>Athens Food Tour</i> We strolled across the streets and visited several restaurants, savoring the Mediterranean diet. We tried the classic meat gyros (souvlaki skewers) served with warm pita bread and cold Greek beer, cheese pie (Greek tyropita), Greek salad, Greek donuts, etc. Our knowledgeable guide provided us with insights about how food had an in-depth relationship with Greek culture. Even the pita pies are made differently in different areas due to historical factors, e.g., wars.		
Reflections: I can see that the language exposure and food tasting experience, coupled with the history course the previous day, completes the sketch of what Greek culture is like. Our language learning experience had an implicit connection to the situation faced by refugees. I gradually empathized with the feeling of helplessness that refugees encountered in their lives, living in a completely different country with a different language. Even with an experienced teacher, we still found it difficult to adapt to the complexities existing in the language. It is likely that overcoming the obstacles in mastering Greek requires persistence and resilience. Similarly, refugees must demonstrate resilience in the face of language barriers, cultural differences, and past traumas as they strive to learn a new language in a challenging environment. The first-hand experience from our language learning underscored the importance of community engagement and social integration for refugees as they learn a new language and build connections in Greece while interacting with native speakers in Greek culture. I also immersed myself in urban environments, where I attempted to read street signs aloud, navigating unfamiliar surroundings and deepening the cultural experience. I pondered about the insights that traditional Greek dishes have revealed into a culture's history, agriculture, trade routes, and societal norms. Ingredients such as olive oil, honey, grains, and wine have been central to Greek cuisine for millennia, adapted to the climatic conditions near the Mediterranean Sea. Contemporary Greek cuisine also reflects more recent historical developments, such as the fusion of traditional recipes with modern cooking techniques and global culinary trends, serving residents' appetite in their everyday lives. Stimulating views and the flourishing tourism developments have fortunately supported the growth of its economy by attracting groups of visitors from worldwide, after the COVID-19 breakdown. Tourism is not just a way of generating revenues; it has also supported a country by creating job opportunities, enabling infrastructural development, and most importantly, it has allowed small businesses such as souvenir shops and family-restaurants to thrive and flourish.		

Question: *How can the refugees receive language empowerment?*

Response:

The experience at Za'atar and Falite Center could answer the question.

- In Za'atar's day center available for the public, language classes are provided to offer practical conversational skills tailored to refugees' needs. Za'atar has also shown the ability to adapt to the COVID-19 outbreak by shifting face-to-face classes to online platforms (even volunteers living in different time zones could get involved), which enhances mobility and increases capability.
- In the Falite center, the two officers took the initiative to teach children English with their own learning experiences of English as a first language. This has addressed the gap of continual education at an early age of a child refugee.

Question: *How can I distinguish myself from a voluntourist?*

Response:

I was aware that the experiences in the first two days are full of tourism elements. Hence, I bore the thought that I shall change my tourist mindset in lateral days where my effort in understanding the cultural context could be transitioned toward more meaningful idea exchanges when visiting different NGOs. It would be of utmost importance to show respect for the community about their traditions and the way of life during our activity. Different from voluntourists who make a change in their visiting country, I shall also consider how I could apply the knowledge to contribute to social issues that exist in the place where I live.

Day 3	Date: June 10, 2024	Athens, Greece
Observations: <i>Refugee Law by Lawyer Farmakidis</i> In this lecture, our speaker tossed out a lot of technical jargon that provided a dense layer of specialized terminology permeating the rigor and specificity of legal discourse. Although it is not my area of focus, I found its intrinsic value since Mr. Farmakidis provided a comprehensive definition for each of the terms. Notions between “refugee” (<i>a person outside the country of origin due to persecution</i>) and “asylum seekers” (<i>a person who has entered a host country and expressed the will to be recognized as a refugee</i>) are often mixed up, but each of them is endowed with different ranges of rights defined by official law. We also learned that the 1951 Refugee Convention and its 1967 Protocol are the key legal documents governing basic refugee rights. More interestingly, the speaker introduced several philosophical frameworks. For example, David Miller took <i>liberal nationalism</i> as his philosophical viewpoint. Miller emphasizes that individuals have special obligations to their fellow citizens based on a shared national identity and membership in a political community, which creates a moral and legal bond. Moreover, Miller suggests that there may be a threshold limiting the number of refugees in a country that can effectively accommodate while fulfilling its obligations to provide adequate protection and support. It is important to recognize the interests of host societies and balance the rights of refugees with the concerns of local populations, as exceeding the limit could potentially justify deferring responsibility for hosting refugees to other countries. <i>First NGO visit: Za’atar (Tastes of Damascus)</i> A genuine humanity. I was deeply touched by how truthful and selfless the co-founder, Marina Liakis, of the organization had expressed during the “chat”. We went to the restaurant called Taste of Damascus, which serves vegetarian Middle Eastern cuisine. The restaurant also offers training and job opportunities to asylum seekers and refugees. Za’atar also provides a holistic shelter (the <i>Orange House</i> for up to 15 refugee women) for people who have encountered domestic violence. They have addressed basic living needs such as showering facilities, language workshops, and food tasting activities that enhance livelihood support limited by the number of organizations available. Za’atar NGO has the strength of empowering refugees as the co-founder attempts to provide different job opportunities that enrich the refugee’s job profile, with the boutique shop, beauty salon, and a Syrian-style restaurant. For the restaurant operated by Za’atar that we have visited, the food quality is above standard, with the famous Middle East dishes falafel, hummus dipping, and the Syrian rose-flavored milk pudding. Hence, it is justifiable from the food that Za’atar had gained its popularity and support by neighborhoods due to its meticulous devotion.		
Reflections: Greece belongs to the Continental legal system, and its legal origins are based on statutory law, whereas Hong Kong's legal system is based on the principles of the common law tradition. These distinct legal frameworks shape how each jurisdiction approaches various legal issues. <i>Asylum Shopping and Smugglers</i> During the debriefing session, we encountered the term “asylum shopping.” The concept of "asylum shopping" refers to the practice where asylum seekers strategically choose their destination country based on perceived benefits or advantages in the asylum process, such as better living conditions, comprehensive legal protections, or more favorable reception policies. It has negative implications as some individuals may exploit differences in asylum policies and procedures to secure benefits that go beyond basic humanitarian assistance. If Miller were to address the issue of asylum shopping, he might argue that states have a primary duty to their own citizens to maintain social cohesion and provide for the common good. He might also advocate for a balanced approach, considering the interests of both refugees and host societies, and recognize that hosting an excessive number of asylum seekers may not be sustainable. From a liberal nationalist perspective, Miller might acknowledge the rights of individuals to seek better prospects and pursue their interests through migration, while also recognizing the importance of national identity and shared values within the destination country. Refugee protections are impossible without the support from the United World's corporations. There are still debates on how better care can be provided without discriminating against different ethnic groups. I believe that policymakers should focus more on fair distributions of refugees in their future works.		

Diversity of Workplaces around Our Neighborhood

Having visited a “social enterprise,” I pondered and realized that such businesses are all around Hong Kong. These social enterprises are guided by a mission to create a positive impact on society or the environment, operating across education, healthcare, environment and employment sectors. In fact, our participation in purchasing or making donations could support their work in an encouraging manner. These enterprises also generate job opportunities that reach the broader minority groups, eventually leading to greater social inclusion and equality. Even more, the environmental enterprises promote sustainability through eco-friendly practices, waste reduction, and renewable energy solutions. This has provided a localized solution that can be scaled up to address broader issues. Hence, our effort can even bring a change to the planet Earth, toward the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).

Question: *How can the term “decolonization of classical education” relate to the experiences of the trip?*

This question was raised by one of the Junior Fellows during the debriefing session. I think that not many of us had understood its actual meaning without searching online. One interpretation is that one’s trip experiences and their engagement with diverse cultures and histories could enrich the understanding of the world beyond traditional textbooks. “Decolonization” then refers to the act of challenging and expanding the views prevalent in classical education. Through the critical reflection on the colonial legacy, we could include the marginalized factors into considerations and demonstrate the plurality of human experiences and knowledge systems.

Question: *How have Za’atar NGO’s explanations of their work associated with the lecture on legal aid?*

As the background story of a refugee serves as the foundation toward successful application, the Greek government does carry the assumption that every applicant bears the knowledge of how to describe their situations that led to asylum seeking, which is often not the case. Za’atar NGO’s approach of empowering refugees to articulate their experiences effectively ensures that every applicant is given a fair opportunity to present their case and establish their eligibility for asylum based on their individual circumstances, valuing the unique stories and perspectives of refugees. The reasoning is that Greek refugee law emphasizes the importance of conducting individualized assessments of asylum claims to determine the credibility of applicants. Even more importantly, having these applicants be truthful has also played an important role for the government to realize the importance of providing human rights to refugees and determining an appropriate level of protection.

Day 4	Date: June 11, 2024	Athens, Greece
Observations: <i>Fáilte Centre</i> The word “Fáilte” means “welcome.” The Fáilte Centre was co-founded in 2022 by Colleen and Claire, providing learning opportunities and mental health support services in a warm and welcoming environment. I first noticed how their identities have shaped the center’s mission statement, as their philosophy is to treat every visitor as individuals who deserve dignified, tailored responses to their specific concerns and needs. The Fáilte Centre offers a range of English classes from basic to advanced writing skills. Most importantly, the organization supports people from all walks of life – regardless of age, gender, background, nationality, or region. This is important for migrants and refugees who have faced extreme hardship and discrimination in trying to build new lives. The Fáilte Centre also collects both quantitative data (age, attendance rate, etc.) and qualitative data (comments and feedback). In this way, they can establish a measure to assess the satisfaction and performance of their work. As a start-up without much popularity at the beginning, the Fáilte Centre has explored their way out. I appreciate their courage to reach out to medical and legal organizations searching for refugees who need assistance. They also believe that a word-of-mouth spreading approach could lead to echoes when coupled with their promotion on social media.		
Reflections: The visit to Fáilte center was a warm experience. Memo notes on the board are testimonials reflecting how they have devoted themselves to creating a truly welcoming atmosphere. Even if they are unable to serve all those in need due to a shortage of workforce, they still encourage them to pay a visit so they can have a suitable level of expectation. Grants are also used to respond to popular requests for a knitting and crocheting circle at the Fáilte Centre. I appreciate how they have used hobby building as a tool to calm the needy in the stressful, stimulating surroundings. As a new organization, they have taken a step to evaluate their work through an annual report in 2023. What I believe is important to them is how they choose to manage volunteers effectively. One positive aspect of recruitment is that they have attempted to match volunteers with specific skills. For example, those interested in childcare would be assigned to the kids' area, while those holding an English teaching certificate could work on language teaching courses. While having a larger number of volunteers can provide them with more power to effect change, the balance in management is more crucial: a lack of coordination could lead to disagreements that hinder the decision-making process. With more capabilities, the two co-founders can focus more on effective leadership by clearly defining roles and responsibilities for each volunteer. I also think they could develop a conflict resolution mechanism with regular feedback and evaluation, which is crucial to maintain a harmonious working environment.		
Questions: <i>What are the challenges that the Fáilte Center have faced, and how do they explore their way out?</i> In Colleen and Claire’s opinion, they have expressed frustration against the government’s austerity in their untimely funding application processes (which was informed in the refugee law lecture). Hence, <i>credibility</i> always presents as a factor when they design questionnaires for refugees. The overtime working schedule has also forced them to learn a work-life balance when dealing with specific requests. The need is strong and necessary as their job requires good emotional control and the ability to overcome stress. Furthermore, they have also expressed distress about their financial stress due to the government’s lack of support (stringent unrestricted funding). As the government only processes grant proposals, every decision that the Fáilte center makes must be associated with realistic concerns of how their work could be presented. How they managed this stress is fully by <i>persistence</i> and a bit of <i>hope</i> with the comments that they have received. By their strength of clearly recognizing the local context and demands, and the “good vibes and memories” that they continue to spread, these challenges could eventually be addressed with their continual development and experiences in the community.		

Day 5	Date: June 12, 2024	Athens, Greece
Observations: <i>KHORA</i> The KHORA free shop that we visited provides clothing, blankets and toiletries. We stood in a semi-circle around the counter and listened to the basic information about the organization. The person-in-charge explained KHORA's organization in his affirmative tone, with very high confidence that it could lead to better management and better agreement among all members. - KHORA welcomes "people in need," providing them a sense of control ("right to choose"). They hold the view that <i>everyone has the right to choice, autonomy, dignity, community and the ability to access the basic means to live</i>. Privacy is the basic human right that they place emphasis on. - They defined themselves as an "international, non-hierarchical <i>collective</i>" group with members from all continents and backgrounds. The organization makes agreements based on mutual understanding and continuous discussions, best for their consensus. For example, if anyone has expressed any concern, the organization will track the issue until the problem is fully resolved. Even if they are acknowledged about the time-consuming and the delays that it could bring to emergency issues, they believe that it is the best for their transparency. Also, different working groups make their own decisions independently. Only issues affecting the whole body will be raised in delegate meetings and assemblies. They view it as a challenge against society on the stereotypical understanding of organizational structures, ensuring that equal treatment for everyone in the organization. - To stand with displaced people, KHORA does not accept fundings that causes or contributes to the border crisis. They also maintain a dominant position by rejecting funding that impose specific requirements controlling KHORA's work. This way, they remain free from being labeled as an NGO, charity, or government-supported entity that may be expected to have certain responsibilities that violate the value of not dividing humans into categories. <i>Doctors of the World (MdM)</i> We visited the Open Polyclinic in Athens, mainly providing primary healthcare and social and psychological support to people belonging to vulnerable social groups. The polyclinic consists of four rooms providing different types of specialized care, with services offered by cardiologists, psychiatrists, gynecologists, dentists, and pediatricians. Compared to our pre-trip readings, MdM has demonstrated its ability to cover most areas requested for primary healthcare, showcasing the comprehensiveness of the polyclinic. The core area of Greece, Athens, also demonstrates a difference in service capability compared to migrant camps. While migrant camps lack dentists, contraception advice services, and neonatal care, the polyclinic is equipped with specialists who can cover these critical areas with their dentists and gynecologists. The polyclinic also houses sophisticated medical equipment such as an X-ray machine and an ultrasound scanning machine, enabling on-site screening and efficient diagnosis. I also observed a considerable number of syringes stored on the shelf in the room, indicating a demand for vaccination services. Free or minimally charged services are provided to refugees whenever possible, as they strongly advocate that "health is a fundamental human right for everyone."		

Reflections:

On Wikipedia, the word “Khôra” is said to be used by Plato to designate a receptacle space, not admitting destruction. The diverse range of cultural and political backgrounds and traditions reminded me a sense of trust and self-dependency.

How can the term “common ground” be applied to the organization KHORA?

KHORA’s definition of their organizational structure has refined the way that I interpret Ivan Illich’s concept of “*common ground*.” Even if some members of KHORA are from foreign countries, they shared a deep commitment with members in the community to uphold the dignity and rights of all individuals, regardless of their background or circumstances. This action emphasizes the common values and diversity of their members, bridging differences. By rejecting certain fundings and maintaining independence, they have also made a commitment to ethical principles resonating with the concept of common ground, where shared values of a community guide their actions and decision-making.

However, I have some critiques of the stability of the organization. I have deep concerns about their fundraising adequacy as they do not accept government funds and consistently have to spend money on groceries. Even if the community is eager to help, I doubt they can maintain a variety of products. In my opinion, they need diverse fundraising sources such as grants and partnerships. Instead of rejecting *all* proposed, restrictive funds, I encourage KHORA to consider those aligned with their intention. It is of utmost importance to share their effort in maintaining the organization under such a challenge that their work is accomplished through agreement. In this manner, KHORA could prioritize impactful projects that they were not able to complete and reduce reliance on single funding streams. On the other side, I worry about the risk of newcomers causing harm to organizations like KHORA through malicious actions such as initiating raids that could violate the core values of the organization. As this challenge is unique to KHORA, they may need to implement background checks (which they tried not to do) and reference procedures to ensure that members are aligned with KHORA’s missions and visions. They should also consider developing a crisis response plan that outlines steps to address emergencies or disruptive situations. Otherwise, without real protocols, the arbitrariness of the community could lead to internal fragmentations that are invisible, posing threats.

How can we interpret KHORA host’s description of the government as “fascist”?

In a historical context, “Fascist” is associated with authoritarianism, nationalism, and suppression of dissent. Assessing the political climate in Greece, the government’s strict control measures, including surveillance, restrictions on movement, and harsh enforcement of immigration laws. Xenophobic feelings toward refugees are also perpetuated due to the exercise of exclusion of “outsiders” with the government’s frequent choices to prioritize the nation’s citizens, which lead to marginalization, stigmatization and denial of rights. These feelings are valid, as all of these are first-hand experiences, contributed by the special demographic composition of the organization.

How did MdM’s identity positively contribute to their values and influences on the populations being served?

When it comes to highly specialized work, Doctors of the World have demonstrated a resolute and positive attitude through their courageous provision of professional services. This dedication has the potential to transform the bureaucratic, austere, and understaffed landscape within the Greek NHS. Describing the project implementation as “not easy but doable” underscores their massive commitment to refugee aid, playing a pivotal role in supporting refugee camps with their profound understanding of the community cultivated over 13 years. Similarly to KHORA, MdM upholds a code of conduct that prioritizes safeguarding the information privacy of refugees by restricting access for unrelated personnel. This not only showcases a deep commitment to respecting rights and dignity but also fosters trust between refugees and humanitarian organizations. This trust-building aspect is crucial, particularly in a medical context, and should be diligently addressed to ensure successful operations and sensitive interactions with refugees who may harbor delicate sentiments towards external entities.

Day 6	Date: June 13, 2024	Lesvos Island, Greece
Observations: <i>Lesvos Camp</i> (Mavrovouni Camp and Moria Camp) In November 2022, the existing Lesvos camp structure was transformed from a Reception and Identification Centre (RIC) to a Closed Controlled Access Centre (CCAC). Originally, newly arrived asylum seekers could be stranded in the Controlled Accommodation Facility for asylum seekers at West Lesvos for more than two weeks, waiting in dire conditions. During their time in the camp, asylum seekers may live without official registration, access to interpretation, legal or psychosocial assistance, information on procedures, or the ability to contact anyone outside the quarantine area. This situation could lead to arbitrary practices, such as pushback operations. It was only in late May 2023 that all newcomers were transferred directly to the CCAC at Mavrovouni. We were first led into an office operated by UNHCR (UN Refugee Agency), where we were introduced to the situation at the Lesvos Refugee Camp. The Mavrovouni camp is organized into four main zones – blue, yellow, green, and red, hosting people based on their profiles (vulnerable, single men, families) and the status of their asylum application. The camp is divided into colored zones according to the single/family dynamic, gender/sex, and nationalities. While families and most single women have been moved to containers, numerous tents designated for single women and men are still in place. These tents contain multiple “rooms” that two or three people now have to share. - We learned that there are five operational units: information dissemination unit, mental health and medical unit, identification unit, safety and security unit and camp service unit. It is worth noting that the camp services are outsourced to external companies. - Without papers stating that one is either a registered asylum seeker or working for an in-camp registered NGO there is no chance of entering. We had to sign a sheet to indicate that our visit was arranged by the NGO MdM. - We were accompanied by a police patrol car to ensure our safety, but some of my peers expressed concerns about potential limitations on our observations, which contradicted the intended purpose of the visit. - The basic infrastructure of the camp includes sport facilities, educational classrooms, and is supported by five operational units. - The weather was scorching hot, reaching temperatures of up to 42 degrees Celsius or higher, significantly increasing the risks of heat strokes. The camp relied solely on fans and ventilators, leading to the trapping of heat inside, creating unbearable conditions for its inhabitants. While they may have access to a phone, the connection to family, information, and any form of distraction is often impossible for a considerable portion of the day. Additionally, the peak of arrivals typically occurs during the summer months, surpassing the 4,000-capacity limit most of the time, with numbers occasionally surging to as high as 6,000.		
Reflections: Between the institutional interplay, bare minimum living conditions, overcrowded housing, and the aggressive behavior of the police, people are constantly under pressure and stress. Mental health conditions have emerged as the most common health problem among people residing in migrant camps (56.3%, Farmakioti et al., 2022). Psychological health support is virtually non-existent, with no on-site psychiatrist offering immediate assistance to address pressing needs. Behind the scenes, I learned after the visit that asylum applicants would need to pay €100 to reapply after an initial rejection of their asylum claim. How are people expected to generate money while living marginalized lives? This was indeed a traumatizing experience, with all indications pointing towards negative outcomes – time, money, and attitude. After all they have been through, no one could be expected to maintain a positive outlook. I can empathize with their plight.		

A Moral Dilemma during Our Dinner

While having dinner with my group of friends, a pregnant woman approached us. Actually, it is not too far to say that she was targeting on us, for free food to sustain herself and the “baby” she was carrying. We would have been willing to provide something, but she was quite particular in her preferences. We had to discreetly whisper and cipher our conversation in Cantonese to decide our final offer. Nevertheless, she seemed to have an excessive amount of idea and emphasized that she would like an oily pizza instead of the pasta that would probably be a healthier option. Eventually, most of us were conspiratorial about it and unfortunately the manager of the restaurant asked her to leave. During our debriefing session, we raised our concerns while expressing our regret for not being able to help. Reflecting on our own actions, we had genuinely considered her health concerns and empathized with her needs. However, in hindsight, we could have attempted better communication with her, and respecting her choices and upholding her dignity, before reaching the final decision of not to assist. These reflections underscore our commitment to thinking with greater respect and consideration for the well-being and dignity of others. Even if the world seems to have some levels of extortions, we shall not forget to inspire hope in those around us. This is another lesson learned apart from the trip’s experiences.

Question: *There are different levels of understanding on how the public perceive the organizations in Greece. Why?*

In our group discussions during debriefing, we believe that three factors may contribute to varying perceptions: language barriers, location-based economic and demographic influences, and organizational reputation.

- Language barriers hinder effective communication between organizations and the local population, potentially leading to misunderstandings and feelings of unacceptance. An example is the Syrian-family-founded Za’atar, which described encountering unwelcoming responses from some citizens.
- The locations of NGO operations may be linked to socioeconomic factors, where areas facing economic challenges may exhibit resistance or support based on perceptions of resource competition among the local population. In tourism areas, the presence of refugees may be unwelcome due to potential impacts on business operations. Newer generations may display more empathy towards populations in need.
- Organizational reputation is shaped by historical events and experiences with migration waves, serving as testimonials to an organization's success. MdM is a prime example, showcasing professionalism that has garnered a positive response and amplified their impact in Greece. Time is a key factor in building and shaping this reputation.

Day 7	Date: June 14, 2024	Lesvos Island, Greece
Observations: <i>Fenix</i> Fenix provides asylum seekers and refugees in Greece with a holistic legal aid service that includes legal aid and representation, as well as protection, case management, and mental support. Their mission is to empower refugee communities and remove the barriers that prevent them from having real and effective access to the right of asylum seeking. During our visit, their organization had one <i>full-time</i> lawyer working for asylum applications, and two lawyers working on the strategic push of governmental policies. Similar to MdM, their consulting service requires professionalism, which makes their work unique in the field of refugee aid. Their vision is that <i>every person who is forced to flee has effective, dignified and safe access to the fundamental right to international protection</i>. - Fenix adopts the holistic legal aid approach, combining the work of lawyers, psychologists and protection officers in one case. Upon arrival, refugees have to register for their claimant status. However, the lawyers' special angle of service pushes them to focus on the appeal procedures and the rights that refugees are empowered with during the interview (call for lawyer presence, request breaks, maintain confidentiality, and request interpreter services). - To better equip claimants with the knowledge and confidence to navigate their asylum procedures, Fenix also offers information sessions to help them better understand the service in the context of international protection. This could put these needy people in a better position as their background of race, religion, nationality, political orientation, could be genuine consideration factors that are needed to be addressed during the interview. - Fenix also applies the knowledge obtained during field visits to put rights violations on the agenda of law and policymakers. They lift up the issues to the European Court and aim to attract attention through international complaint mechanisms. For instance, Fenix brought up the case where children are sent to school for only a few weeks, in rotations. In such a short period, there is hardly a chance for these children to learn sustainably and perform social interactions. This is an anecdote to what we have heard from the camp, adding to the inconsistent characteristics of refugee child education rights. Under the Dublin procedure, the organization also urges the government to intervene so that unaccompanied minors or adults applying for international protection can be reunited with family members. Apart from what is explicitly written on the slides, Fenix also explained how negatively the government reacts when handling issues related to refugee aid. I recall that they mentioned policies that decreased arrivals and transferred refugees to detention-like facilities to suppress their motivation to move into Greece. They also emphasized the government imposing control on NGOs without providing adequate funds, which has lowered the quality of services		
Reflection: <i>Leading question: What is the biggest challenge that Fenix is currently facing? How could these risks be mitigated and transformed into opportunities?</i> I truly believe that Fenix has put effort into urging institutional changes in the government. Following up on their social media, I can still see how they challenge the government's inactions on their unfulfilled promises about procedural rights of refugees. With the experiences after visiting the camp, it has enriched my understanding by realizing the implications of the living conditions, as residents still lack access to basic reception conditions like food, water, and financial support. The cycle of neglect and injustice continues. Through discussions with Fenix, we came to an agreement that their timeliness in pursuit of adaptation is the key that would continue to safeguard their success in the future. They are placed in a competitive standing, as they clearly understand that procedures are constantly changing. Still, there are opportunities for them to explore, as they could face the high demand for legal aid assistance. The major obstacle that this organization faces is that refugees are <i>not of the Greek government's interest</i> (agrees with Za'atar, KHORA, etc.). Moreover, some countries even choose to get rid of refugees by paying money. This is an <i>objectification</i> of asylum seekers, as their asylum nature is undermined during the detention without support. As humans, their basic rights are disdained, contributing to their sense of being unwanted. I believe that they should discover ways to attract more future leaders that could sustain the growth in the capability of the organization. With the power of the government that they are facing, they do need more perspectives by recruiting more agents to perform critical analysis and balance the risks of fighting with governmental officers and the opportunities by being aggressive that could maintain their access to refugee camps.		

Day 8	Date: June 15, 2024	Athens, Greece
Observations: <i>Invisible Athens Tour & Shedia</i> In the morning, Michael led us with an insider's view into Athens' homelessness, and then we headed to the café for lunch. [Information omitted, didn't gain many observations. Reasons would be explained below.] Shedia newspaper and Shedia magazine is the only Greek street paper. Not only did they analyze and comment on the political, social, cultural and sporting life of Greece, but they also touched upon the cultural topics. The editorial team of Shedia welcomes both young and experienced, either professional or unprofessional, journalists who are acting upon the principles of objective and independent journalism. Associated with the International Network of Street Papers, the Shedia Magazine is solely sold in the city's streets by approved vendors. The requirement to be a vendor can be simple – as long as they have a special or emerging need (homelessness, unemployed, low-income), and aged above the standard established by the regulations. They work with dignity: the code of conduct does not allow vendors to beg. During the time we visited the restaurant and (simultaneously) handicraft gift shop, we deepened our understanding as they valued the quality over the quantity. This is similar to Za'atar's idea: first it ensures a stable customer inflow, and second it would not want their product to end up in trash bins. Even more, one of their strengths is on the circulatory system (which follows an idea of environmental protection and sustainability) that all the paper wastes could be strategically recycled and reused for their creative products, such as tiny paper baskets, repurposed as fridge magnets, or paper rings. <i>Pride Parade</i> The pride parade marked Greece's first year of legalization of same-sex marriage. However, the motto of this parade "a law is not enough" reflected the sentiment that homophobia in Greek society has not yet been eliminated. It is particularly conservative of the Greek Orthodox Church to act against the legalization, as they emphasized that children have a natural need for a father and a mother, under the context that about 80% to 90% of Greek residents identify themselves as Greek Orthodox. It is a consistent challenge that religions can remain a powerful institution influencing public sentiment and political decisions. While traditions or religions can be important, it is still important to hold a view of change, similar to Christianity, as a resilient response to the modern world. Reflections: The invisible Athens tour did raise my attention to other populations that are vulnerable. The strict management of leave permits in shelters has given me a feeling of the loss of freedom, as every action being done is recorded by the governmental shelter, which is an invasion of privacy. For those who are bearing HIV/infectious diseases, they do not even have a right to claim a shelter, and they bear the risks to survive. It is hard for me to imagine the psychological status and traumatic responses of these people. For them, what is the purpose of survival if life's continuation could not contribute to more happiness? The only hope is to "dream big", as Michael mentioned. In this case, it is the hope for institutional changes. However many times we end up at the trough, we can still hope for someone making an institutional change for us, to accept our feebleness, making a better life for us. <i>Minority rights in Macau...? The Reason why didn't I Feel Strongly to the Tour</i> I did not happen to echo strongly to the tour, as opposed to my peers. I could hardly see any beggars on the street, but it seems to be an actual issue in Hong Kong. In Macau, there is less discrimination shown to minority groups. In my opinion, this can be attributed to the legal framework, cultural diversity, and social inclusion of Macau. - It is stipulated in legislation mechanisms that rights of refugees should not be violated. This ensures quality and non-discrimination based on factors such as race, ethnicity, religion and language. - The historical context of Macau has encouraged the co-existence among different ethnic and cultural groups. During the time that I was in primary school, there were often surveying activities in tourist spots that encouraged the interaction between the youth and different cultural groups. - It has been known about Macau government's effort on social harmony and inclusivity, which has fostered a sense of community and mutual respect among different ethnic groups. I believe that this act has promoted the rights and well-being of minorities, as they treat them the same, as citizens, being a part of Macau. Also, reflecting on the economic stability of Macau, the opportunities for social advancement are not constrained by financial factors, which can be a reason why people generally do not have negative feelings and discrimination toward a specific minority group.		

Student Presentations

This was the most challenging day I had on the trip, with an oral presentation and little time for preparation. I panicked. We presented our only NGO fully specialized in medical aid, Doctors of the World (MdM). While most of the information was retrieved from MdM's website, I tried to collect information about how the organization defines vulnerability and summarized the challenges mentioned in the readings. Ultimately, we addressed several key questions with non-trivial answers.

- *What are the stances of vulnerability defined by MdM? What specific groups do they target?*

We conducted a literature review based on the MdM Annual Report 2022, aiming to understand how the organization defines their line for the minority groups that require the most medical assistance. In addition to supporting asylum seekers, MdM also directs its attention towards the homeless population. They have also provided mobile medical services which can cater to people's needs in remote areas. We observe that the specific scope of vulnerability might be due to the geographic locations (islandic nature) of Greece and the significance of the EU framework setting up the baseline standard.

- *What challenges were MdM facing in the case of RIC camps?*

We questioned the mental services in the Mavrovouni camp. The only psychiatrist had left, signaling the absence of mental health services. Many of whom experienced trauma, displacement are unable to access spontaneous mental aids. We believe that the government should integrate mental health services with primary healthcare to ensure a holistic approach, addressing both physical and mental needs.

- *How did MdM use its tactics to guarantee the stability of its establishment?*

- **Nature of the organization:** MdM recognizes itself as an autonomous organization, without the interference of government control. In this way, they receive support from different sectors of society, but they have retained the ability to express opinions and push for changes that eventually enhance the lives of vulnerable groups.
- **Organizational structure:** The organization has a clear, separated role of work. In contrast to KHORA's flat structure that enhanced idea communication during the decision process, MdM stands on the other extreme with its hierarchy. The drawback associated is that upper management could play a bigger role in discussions, which leads to a weakened feeling of coordination and significant overhead and unnecessary delays in detecting unexpected problems.
- **Collaborations:** Working in partnership with local organizations, governments, and other NGOs helps MdM establish a strong presence and network within the communities it serves. The deep connections and long-term experiences of MdM could even motivate their peer organizations.
- **Volunteer programs:** Through the involvement of healthcare professionals and volunteers in its missions, not only does it enhance the organization's operational capacity, but it also fosters a sense of community and shared purpose.

- *How is the Greek Medical Healthcare System different from Hong Kong's?*

Greece maintains a universal healthcare system that offers coverage to all citizens and legal residents, funded through a mix of social insurance contributions, general taxation, and out-of-pocket payments. Greece emphasizes primary care as a cornerstone of its healthcare approach. We have seen on the streets with plentiful pharmacies with clear signboards as the first line of defense against diseases. In contrast, Hong Kong operates a dual-track system with a strong public sector managed by the Hospital Authority alongside a robust private sector. Hong Kong's healthcare system is characterized by efficiency, high-quality care, and advanced medical facilities, with healthcare primarily funded through general taxation and government subsidies. The two regions face different challenges: while Greece is strained by the National Health System due to economic issues, Hong Kong's demand for emergency services is seriously burdened by factors associated with its aging population and public preferences for immediate medical attention. Through our effort, I believe that we have underscored the importance of developing tailored solutions and strategic plans that may have important influences on the healthcare systems.

My groupmates have noticed that in such a large-scale organization, it is inevitable that statistical data, being quantitative measurements, solely represents indicators for measuring success. It is hard to capture the complexities they face when implementing the projects.

Problems encountered: *With MdM's layers of management and decision-making processes, it is hard to perform critical analyses about the provision of medical aid, designated for refugees in the camp.* Bearing this vast scope of work has limited the depth of analysis that they could perform, which is the major reason why we could not finish the presentation easily. This also implies another disadvantage of an NGO, since its large amount of data slows down the decision-making processes. The focus on presenting their polished data not only hinders public understanding of real matters, but it could also divert resources away from core activities with its complicated processing procedures. The organization should not only consider the data presented to the public, but it should also anticipate that the shortage may imply a larger problem in the quality of services. I suggest that they periodically review their data processing practices to identify areas for improvement.

Section III.

Post-trip Reflections	Date: September – November, 2024	CUHK, Hong Kong
I have experienced a strong conflict between the core values presented in this course (the “academic” side) and my personal values. To be clear, I found it impossible to raise grounded critiques of an organization without sufficient understanding of the long-term impacts that these organizations might have sustained. I also wondered whether it is even humane to assess a country’s internal structures from a moral high ground. Even if it is theoretically possible to justify every step with ethics, is it feasible to implement the hypothesized policy in real life? When I eventually started asking everyone the question, many of my peers either replied that the public will never see our papers, or they seemed to think that blindly finishing coursework is a relief that is way more important than any potential harms. Indeed, our essay would eventually be supported by research, but it is difficult to recognize whether our misinterpretation or misunderstanding during the discussion session had perpetuated stereotypes when we apply our experiences to the analysis provided by the journal articles. I had to raise a red-flagged concern here. Even worse, I felt awfully disappointed that several journal articles written by a group of authors even contained simple typo mistakes or punctuation errors, which detract from the overall quality of the work. This type of “excessive publishing” behavior is ruining the reputation in academia, as they only prioritize the quantity of publications over the rigor and impact of their work. At one point, I doubted even that my awareness in addressing the biases that may be present would not affect how I finish the course. I was (in fatigue) trapped into thinking that the knowledge I was equipped with is not going to help the community. Later, I did start to discover a small set of objective views when it comes to how information systems could be utilized for storing and sharing medical records in digital form, which was not seen in the refugee’s case. I drew the conclusion as I ran into several NGO websites with poor web user interface (UI) designs, that I could tell that the government should assist in training more web design and computer specialists. This would be the biggest gem that I discovered throughout the course, where I found my identity as a computer science student could potentially urge for a change. Playing the podcast once again, I recognized one difference from what was mentioned in the podcast and what was discussed in the class. I had to admit that little was shared in the course about how our experiences could be transferred to the society we locate ourselves in, during the tutorial discussions. [However, at this moment of writing, I have the answer in mind, and there are chances that it is not the best way of how we use the tutorial discussions.] I recalled the experiences while working in government, handling documents about expenditures for city development. How they handled the bid was a no-brainer – simply choose a corporation whose plan involves the least money. I saw my managers focus mostly on the accounting aspect: as long as the sum is correct, the budget gets approved. With the amount of work that they manage, it is hard to call for a change, or even question the decisions made by other departments. The criteria for detecting a wrong decision are just too hard to define, and too rigid. In the podcast, one also mentioned that the process of gaining access out of the camp is too complicated since refugees have to get their identities recorded with signature and confirmation, and the refugee interview often asks confusing questions that lead to the denial of refugee status. On the one hand, it is essential for policymakers and administrators to continuously evaluate and improve their policies. On the other hand, I couldn’t see how the process could be optimized, which is unfair to policymakers if we do not specify any changes that could have been made. Indeed, there may be officers abusing their screening systems to trick refugees during the interview. However, if we were to oversimplify the process, how could the local residents’ resources be optimally utilized? I believe that these kinds of concerns must couple with a feasible plan, which makes it constructive. [I would agree with scanning the ID card though, for each entry and exit, to alleviate the human power required.] I consider that the most important aspect of the course is to learn how the organizations operate, no matter if it is small, consisting of 2 people, or it is a giant association with systematic management. I had seen the case of small start-up NGOs like the Fáilte Center that contributed effectively to society by their own set of knowledge and skills. On the contrary, large-scale international organizations like Mdm also drove aspiring changes by their vision and long-term experiences. Answering my own concern, service should not be only limited to volunteer work, it can take many forms including professional work, advocacy, mentorship, philanthropy, and various other ways of giving back to the community or making a positive impact on society. At the moment that I realized this fact, I felt pretty satisfied with how I behave in my life, with my refined definition: <i>The ultimate goal of service is to create a more connected, supported, and compassionate community.</i>		

